Nikita Obraztsov

Computational Social Scientist
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Research Profile

Studies how network structure and social influence decide whether a minority keeps its norms under majority pressure. Builds agent-based models of opinion dynamics and derives individual-level quantities that surveys and network data can measure. Main empirical case: religious minorities, drawing on prior training in religious studies.

Interests: opinion dynamics and social influence; social networks, segregation and homophily; committed minorities and norm change; agent-based modelling, validation and reproducibility; measurement of social constructs; computational sociology of religion.

Education

European University at St. Petersburg, School of Computational Social Sciences — Sep 2025 – Present
MA in Sociology, programme "Computational Sociology"; additional master's qualification in Applied Informatics — *Saint Petersburg, Russia*

- Expected graduation: June 2027.
- Thesis (in progress): *Local In-group Share and the Persistence of Minority Norms: An Agent-Based Model of Social Influence in Segregated Networks.* Supervisor: Dr. Evgeny Kotelnikov.

St. Petersburg State University — Sep 2018 – Jun 2020
MA in Religious Studies, with distinction — *Saint Petersburg, Russia*

- Thesis: *The Brights Movement as a Phenomenon of Contemporary Culture.*

Kutafin Moscow State Law University (MSAL) — Sep 2014 – Jun 2018
BA in Law — *Moscow, Russia*

Research Experience

Network Structure and the Persistence of Minority Norms in Agent-Based Models — Nov 2025 – Present
MA thesis research, European University at St. Petersburg — *Saint Petersburg, Russia*

- Built an agent-based model of how network segregation affects the persistence of a minority norm under majority influence (Python, NumPy, NetworkX). Code: github.com/nikobraztsov/abm-secularization.
- Rebuilt it around one mechanism, bounded-confidence influence weighted by commitment, and tested it with parameter sweeps, ablation, mean-field and fixed-network baselines, and sensitivity analysis.
- Extended it to minority sizes from 2 to 50 percent on block and growing networks: most of the apparent size effect came from the per-pair parameterization of cross-group ties, and persistence followed the local share of in-group neighbours (threshold about 0.85).
- Current direction: linking the model to ego-network survey data and longitudinal network panels.

Reanalysis of a Published Religiosity Measure — Mar 2026 – May 2026
Course project in survey methodology, European University at St. Petersburg — *Saint Petersburg, Russia*

- Reanalysed the open replication data of Rainero, Stolz and Luijkx (2026) on religiosity and judgements of secularization among researchers. Code: github.com/nikobraztsov/faith-factor-reanalysis.

- Tested the dimensionality of the religiosity score (parallel analysis, reliability), split it into belief and practice, and estimated logistic models with author-clustered errors, average marginal effects, and a direct test of coefficient equality. The subscales correlate at 0.83 and a direct test cannot separate their effects.

Operationalization of Religiosity in the Empirical Literature 2025 – Present

Independent project *Saint Petersburg, Russia*

- Building a corpus pipeline and a dictionary-based extraction of measurement instruments; a preliminary pass over about 8,000 Q1 articles shows strong concentration on a few simple measures.

Research Presentations

Obraztsov, N. (2026). "Agent-Based Modelling in the Sociology of Religion: Possibilities and Limits of the Method." All-Russian Roundtable "Methodological Strategies of Religiosity Research," Center for Islamic Studies, Academy of Sciences of the Republic of Tatarstan, Kazan, October 2026. Presented online, in Russian.

Obraztsov, N. (2026). "Network Segregation as a Buffer Against Secularization: An Agent-Based Model." 8th European Conference on Social Networks (EUSN 2026), Linköping University, Norrköping, Sweden, August 2026. Presented remotely.

Obraztsov, N. (2026). "Intergroup Connectivity and Religious Resilience: Building an Agent-Based Model of an Orthodox Religious Community." Research seminar, International Laboratory for Applied Network Research, HSE University, Moscow, June 2026. Presented online, in Russian.

Obraztsov, N. (2026). "Structural Limits of Religious Minority Resilience in Secular Society: An Agent-Based Modelling Approach." All-Russian Conference with International Participation "Studies of Religion: Past, Present, Future," St. Tikhon's Orthodox University and Russian State University for the Humanities, Moscow, April 2026. Presented online, in Russian.

Obraztsov, N. (2025). "The Concept of 'Belonging Without Believing' in the Context of Orthodox Identity Formation in Russia." VII All-Russian Sociological Congress, Moscow, November 2025. In Russian.

Summer Schools

AI and Methods in Computational Communication Summer School (AIM-CC 2026) Aug 2026

Poster: "Network Topology as a Buffer Against Secularization: A Structural Mechanism in an Agent-Based Model." Certificate *Astana, Kazakhstan*

VII Summer Sociological School Jun 2026

Higher School of Contemporary Social Sciences, Lomonosov Moscow State University. Certificate *Moscow, Russia*

Publications

Obraztsov, N. A. (2025). "The Concept of 'Belonging Without Believing' in the Context of Orthodox Identity Formation in Russia." In *Sociology and Society: Formation and Functioning of Social Memory. Proceedings of the VII All-Russian Sociological Congress.* In Russian.

Obraztsov, N. A. (2024). *Religions of the World: How to Decipher the Sacred Side of Humanity.* Moscow: Bombora (Eksmo). 208 pp. ISBN 978-5-04-192309-9. Popular-science book, in Russian.

Teaching and Science Communication

Radio contributor, "Fiziki i Liriki" 2026 – Present
Radio Mayak. Eight programmes on religion, atheism and science *Russia*

Lecturer, Religious Studies strand, and course mentor 2022 – Present
Pravoe Polusharie Introverta (Introvert), public education platform *St. Petersburg, online*

- 139 lectures in the active catalogue (July 2026), from surveys of world religions to monographic courses, among them seven lectures on Durkheim and the sociology of religion; one of the three most-watched lecturers on the platform.
- Mentor of the professional retraining course "Culturologist" (250 academic hours).
- Host of the podcast "Ne Day Bog!" (2024), 15 episodes on religion and belief.

Private tutor in social studies 2020 – 2022
Freelance. Preparation of school students for social studies olympiads *St. Petersburg, online*

Author of the YouTube channel "Nikita Obraztsov" 2016 – Present
youtube.com/@Nikobraz. Religion and society; 10,000 subscribers, 860,000 views *Online*

Awards & Honors

3rd place, IV All-Russian Student Research Olympiad "Sociologist in the 21st Century" 2026
Held in partnership with VCIOM and Russian Field. Laureate in three of its competitions: video essay, survey analytics, autoethnography

Finalist, Khrustalny Pingvinopitek 2023
National competition for popular-science video (Antropogenez.ru)

Specialized Skills

Programming: Python (NumPy, pandas, NetworkX, matplotlib; parallel simulation experiments); R (tidyverse, ggplot2, psych, marginaleffects, tidymodels, tidytext, topicmodels, stm, rvest)
Methods: agent-based modelling, social network analysis, regression with clustered errors and marginal effects, factor analysis and scale reliability, causal diagrams (DAGs), random forests, topic models (LDA, STM), web scraping
Tools: Git and GitHub, LaTeX, R Markdown, Gephi
Media: Final Cut Pro (video editing)
Languages: Russian (native), English (advanced; academic writing and presentations)
Membership: Russian Religious Studies Society (Russkoe religiovedcheskoe obshchestvo)

Other Interests

Running: marathon in 3:57, 10 km in 46:58
Games: snooker, chess